were non-binding, and many feared that Netanyahu would simply ignore them.

Several days after the final march, Tel Aviv decided to dismantle the tent city, and municipal officials were sent to serve notice. At first they came bearing flowers, but they returned the next morning with pickup trucks, and hauled away the tents and the accumulated trash. The protesters called them “Nazis in municipal uniforms” (a surprisingly tame insult in Israel—it is also deployed in supermarket checkout lines). Activists made a few half-hearted attempts to restart the protests, but none of them were successful.

Three years later, Ya’akov’s prediction seemed accurate. The government did take a few steps to lower the cost of living. The mobile phone industry was opened to competition in 2012, which sent prices tumbling. An unlimited monthly package now costs less than it does in America. The communications ministry estimated in 2013 that the average family saves nearly $500 per year because of the reforms. Israel is taking steps to privatize the ports in Haifa and Ashdod, a major obstacle to lowering prices in a heavily import-dependent country: the unionized dockworkers are among the country’s highest-paid workers, with some hauling in close to $10,000 per month. And the price of cottage cheese has remained relatively low.

But the overall picture is still bleak. The Taub Center, an economic think tank, reported in 2016 that food prices had increased by 53 per cent over the previous decade. In the United States, during the same period, they climbed by just 27 per cent. Housing prices more than doubled, and by 2014 the average one-bedroom rental in Tel Aviv cost nearly 4,000 shekels, roughly half the median after-tax salary. Wages have been basically flat, which has pushed down home ownership rates: about half of young Israelis owned a home in 2006, but less than 40 per cent do today. A 2015 survey found that two in five Israeli bank accounts are “regularly overdrawn”. Most have an overdraft of more than 5,000 shekels, and they have been in debt for more than a year.

The events of 2011 led to the rise of Lapid’s socioeconomic party in 2013, and drove several prominent activists, like Stav Shaffir, into the Knesset with the Labor Party. Little had improved two years later, and a drip of corruption stories made the prime minister look like a latter-day Marie Antoinette. Most Israelis expected that these issues would decide the looming election.